



A GUIDE FOR INTERNATIONAL BUYERS

The Overseas Buyer's Guide

Buying property from abroad

United Kingdom

United States

UAE / Dubai

Spain

Portugal

Buying abroad is a legal process first, a property search second.

You will be dealing with a legal system, tax rules and a language that may be new to you, often from thousands of miles away. Buyers who get into trouble usually found the right home and skipped a check.

This guide covers the UK, US, UAE (Dubai), Spain and Portugal. Read it before you contact agents, so you know which questions to ask.



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Choosing where to buy

All five markets let foreign nationals own property. What changes is the tax you pay on purchase, the paperwork you need before signing, and who handles the transaction. Start here before you look at listings.

MARKET	WHO CAN BUY	MAIN PURCHASE TAX	KNOW THIS
UK	Anyone, freehold or leasehold	Stamp Duty Land Tax, plus a 2% non-resident surcharge	A further surcharge applies if you already own a home anywhere
US	Anyone, with some state-level restrictions	Set by state and county; no federal purchase tax	Under FIRPTA, 15% of the price can be withheld when you sell
UAE / Dubai	Anyone, in designated freehold areas	4% Dubai Land Department transfer fee	Property worth AED 2M or more can qualify for a 10-year Golden Visa
Spain	Anyone	Regional transfer tax on resales; VAT plus stamp duty on new builds	You need an NIE tax number before you sign
Portugal	Anyone	IMT transfer tax, plus 0.8% stamp duty	You need an NIF tax number to buy or open a bank account



⚠ WARNING

Residency schemes change fast.

Spain and Portugal have both ended property-based golden visas. Never buy on the promise of a visa without checking the current rules with an immigration lawyer.

Buying without being there

You can complete a purchase in all five markets without flying in. It works well when the right people are on the ground and you know which decisions to keep for yourself.



Live video viewings

Ask for a live call, not a pre-recorded tour. Have the agent open cupboards, run taps, and show the view from each window and the street outside.



Power of attorney

Lets your lawyer sign for you. Limit it to this one purchase and set an expiry date. It may need notarising and an apostille in your home country.



Your team on the ground

An independent lawyer, a surveyor and, if you'll rent it out, a property manager. None of them should be paid by the seller.

KEEP THIS DECISION

Delegate the signatures, not the choice. Approve the final contract yourself, in writing, before anyone signs it for you.

The buying process, step by step

The order varies slightly by country, but every purchase from abroad follows these six stages. Most delays come from steps 2 and 5.

01

Set your budget and financing

Lenders often ask non-residents for a larger deposit. Get proof of funds or an agreement in principle first.

02

Get a local tax ID and bank account

Spain (NIE) and Portugal (NIF) require one before you sign. Apply early; appointments can take weeks.

03

Appoint an independent lawyer

Choose your own, not one recommended by the seller or their agent.

04

Make an offer and reserve

Find out whether the reservation deposit is refundable, and under what conditions.

05

Due diligence and contracts

Title, outstanding debts, planning permits and a survey. Sign nothing binding until these clear.

06

Completion and registration

Pay the balance and register the title. A power of attorney lets your lawyer sign if you can't travel.



FRAUD ALERT

Never send money using bank details received by email alone. Confirm them by phone with your lawyer, on a number you already have.

Financing and moving money

How you pay affects your timeline, your total cost and how much paperwork you'll need. Decide this before you make an offer.

OPTION	WORKS WELL WHEN	WATCH FOR
Cash	You want the fastest, simplest purchase and a stronger negotiating position	Currency swings between offer and completion
Local mortgage	You'll earn rent in the local currency to cover repayments	Larger deposits and stricter checks for non-residents
Home-country loan	You have equity in a property at home you can borrow against	Your home is the security, and repayments stay in your home currency



Moving money across borders

- A **forward contract** fixes your exchange rate for a future date, so completion day costs what you planned.
- Compare the exchange rate offered with the mid-market rate. The gap is the real fee.
- Send large amounts to your lawyer's client account, never to the seller or agent directly.

PREPARE EARLY

Anti-money-laundering rules mean you must show where your funds came from. Gather bank statements, sale records or payslips before you make an offer.

Costs and checks

The asking price is only part of what you'll pay. Budget for these costs from the start, and work through the checklist before anything becomes binding.

ON PURCHASE

Taxes and fees

Transfer tax, stamp duty, registration and notary fees.

ON PURCHASE

Professional costs

Lawyer, survey, valuation, translation, and mortgage arrangement.

ON PURCHASE

Currency transfer

Bank exchange spreads add up. A specialist provider can lock in a rate.

EVERY YEAR

Property taxes

Local property or council tax, and non-resident owner taxes where they apply.

EVERY YEAR

Running costs

Service charges, insurance, utilities, and a local property manager.

IF YOU RENT IT OUT

Income tax

Rental income may be taxed locally and at home. Check for a double tax treaty.

Due diligence checklist

- ☐ The seller is the registered owner, and the title is clear of mortgages and liens
- ☐ No unpaid property taxes, utility bills or community fees
- ☐ Building and planning permits match what was actually built
- ☐ An independent survey covers the structure, damp and services
- ☐ For off-plan: the developer's track record and a bank guarantee on deposits
- ☐ Short-term rental licensing, if you plan to let the property
- ☐ A video walkthrough or trusted local viewing if you can't visit

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Check the paperwork as carefully as you check the view.

Most problems for overseas buyers come from title, permit and debt issues found too late.

NEXT STEP

Talk to a buyer's advisor before you commit.

Book a free 30-minute call. We'll review your target market, budget and timeline, and tell you which local specialists you'll need.

Book your free call →

amsispaces.com/consult